Before you begin

Smoking: my diary and my life story

Keeping a diary

Buy a notebook or journal that you keep just for this programme. Start writing in it today, every day until your cohort begins, and keep going through the 33 days. You don't need to change anything yet: just notice, and write it down. Nobody else needs to read it.

Each time you smoke, write down:

- The time, and where you are.
- Whether you are alone, or who you are with.
- What you were doing just before.
- How you felt just before: stressed, bored, tired, anxious, restless, happy.
- How strong the urge was, from 0 to 5.
- Whether this cigarette would be easy or hard to skip.

At the end of each day, write a few lines:

- How many cigarettes did I smoke today?
- Which ones could I have let go of? Which felt hardest to skip, and why?
- What emotions sat underneath my smoking today?
- How did I feel while I was smoking, and afterwards?
- One thing I noticed about myself today.

My life story

Take your time with these. Write in your journal over a few days, as much or as little as feels right. There are no right answers: just be honest with yourself.

1. When did you smoke your first cigarette? How old were you, where were you, and who were you with?

2. What was happening in your life at that time?

3. How long have you smoked? How has it changed over the years: times you smoked more, less, or stopped for a while?

4. What do you smoke now (cigarettes, roll-ups, vapes, cigars), how much, and when?

5. What is smoking a replacement for? What does it give you that you don't get another way: a break, comfort, company, calm, a reward, time to yourself?

6. Which emotions most often lead you to smoke: stress, boredom, loneliness, anger, sadness, celebration?

7. Who in your family smoked, or smokes? What did you learn about smoking growing up?

8. What have you tried before to stop, and what did you learn from it?

9. What does smoking cost you: your health, money, energy, relationships, how you feel about yourself?

10. What has brought you to this group, now?

11. Who are you becoming? Describe a day in your life as someone who no longer smokes.